Ishkhan Khchoian

Legal Counsel — contracts, disputes & cross-border operations

Yerevan, Armenia · remote, or on-site / hybrid in Yerevan · open to relocation
+374 98 60 34 64 · ishxanxchoyan@gmail.com · linkedin.com/in/ishkhan-khchoian-2419182b3
English (C1) · Russian (native) · Armenian (native)

PROFILE

Six years of legal work across three very different environments: civil and contract practice at a Bar Association, a state arbitration court from the inside as a judge's associate, and U.S. immigration practice at three American companies. For an international company that combination is the practical one — I can paper the commercial agreements, see a dispute coming early enough to settle it cheaply, and take on the cross-border employment and immigration work that most in-house teams end up outsourcing. I have also worked in-house, as project manager and the in-house legal support of a family construction and retail business, so I am used to being the only lawyer in the room and being asked for an answer rather than a memo. I am currently COO of the AI startup SayWhen.am, managing its corporate clients across the full engagement cycle.

WHAT I CAN TAKE OFF YOUR DESK

- **Contracts.** Civil-law contract analysis, drafting and claims — first in-house at SIS LLC, where the contracts I reviewed were the ones I then had to deliver against, then at a Bar Association supporting a trade and construction organization.
- **Disputes, seen from the bench.** As judge's associate at the Arbitration Court I drafted judicial acts and managed case materials across **200+ parallel cases and 30+ hearings a week**, covering three roles at once. Knowing how a commercial dispute actually gets decided changes how you write the clause that prevents it.
- **U.S. immigration and relocation.** Owned complex filings end to end — **O-1B, EB-3, E-2** — up to **12 in parallel**, from intake and strategy through evidence to submission; **30 of my clients** were approved for immigrant and non-immigrant talent visas. Directly useful to an Armenia-based employer moving staff, founders or contractors across borders.
- **Legal operations.** At M&M I redesigned the delivery process — a cycle of strictly six months or less, new two- and four-month express tracks, fewer errors through a shared knowledge base and a **35% higher success rate**; at Shamayev I built and taught the **Paralegal Academy**, whose materials went on to serve **50+ people**. Legal teams lose more time to bad process than to hard questions.
- **Managing legal staff.** Coordinated **8 paralegals** at M&M and reviewed their output against defined standards; deputized for the team lead at Shamayev.
- **Commercial literacy.** Tenders, procurement, budgets and delivery schedules — including an investment project of 11 tenders worth RUB 42M — plus project management training in 2026. I know what a "no" from legal costs the business.

LEGAL EXPERIENCE

Freelance — project and legal work Feb 2026 – present

- Designed a U.S. client-acquisition pilot for **Karas Systems** (B2B go-to-market consultancy): a three-scenario funnel model, budget, payback and decision gates.
- Business research for a water production line; CPA/affiliate manager (under NDA); legal projects — IP assignment for works by popular musicians, a corporate structure for a crypto trader and advice on opening a crypto-exchange office in Armenia; sale of family real estate.

Senior Case Manager — M&M Document Preparation (U.S. immigration) Jun 2025 – Feb 2026

- Owned the firm's most complex and highest-value filings end to end — intake, strategy, evidence, submission — up to **12 in parallel** under immovable statutory deadlines.
- Redesigned the delivery process: a cycle of **strictly six months or less**, new **two- and four-month express tracks** and a **35% higher success rate**; **30 of my clients** approved for talent visas.
- Coordinated **8 paralegals**; escalation point on the hard problems.

Paralegal, autonomous caseload — Bloomrich Law Firm Nov 2023 – Aug 2024

- Hired on the strength of previous results and given full autonomy over my caseload, documentation and client communication.

Senior Paralegal — Shamayev Business Law Corp. Feb 2023 – Oct 2023

- Trusted with the firm's key cases; deputized for the team lead.
- Designed and delivered the **Paralegal Academy** — curriculum, materials and teaching; used by **50+ people**.

Judge's Associate — Arbitration Court Nov 2021 – Dec 2022

- Drafted judicial acts, managed case materials and kept document flow moving across **200+ parallel cases** and **30+ hearings a week**.
- Covered **three roles simultaneously** — judge's associate, court specialist and court secretary — normally held by three separate people. Written reference available.

Assistant Lawyer — Bar Association Dec 2019 – Aug 2021

- Analyzed civil-law contracts and prepared claims; provided ongoing legal support to a trade and construction organization.

Project Manager — SIS LLC (family business) Jun 2015 – Sep 2019

- In-house legal support alongside project management: contracts with contractors and suppliers, procurement and transport arrangements, tenders, recruitment and sales.
- Investment project of **11 public and private tenders worth RUB 42M** — every site delivered on time and accepted with no defects noted.

ADJACENT EXPERIENCE

COO — SayWhen.am (AI voice-agent startup) Feb 2026 – present

- Run product development with the CTO in Jira and Confluence: requirements, specification, backlog and priorities, and acceptance of each stage.
- Manage the company's corporate clients across the full engagement cycle: needs discovery, agreement on scope and timelines, and regular progress reporting during implementation.

Event / Project Manager — Hosq Corp. Jan 2025 – Jun 2025

- Vendor contracts, logistics and on-site operations for live events of 100–3,000 people.

Project Manager — Qanon Construction Aug 2024 – Dec 2024

- Client communication, scope agreement, timelines and follow-through.

EDUCATION & TRAINING

- **Project management** — "Project Management with a U.S. Perspective: Skills for Global Success" — Yerevan American Corner, a joint program of the U.S. Embassy Yerevan and the City Central Isahakyan Library; Jul 21 – Aug 21, 2026, in person, Certificate of Achievement.
- **Professional Scrum Master I (Scrum.org)** — exam scheduled for November 2026.
- **Project Management (PM Club)** — 2023, 52 hours.
- **Bachelor of Law, with honors** — North-Eastern State University, 2021.
- **Civil Law, Faculty of Law** — St. Petersburg State University, 2016.

SCOPE NOTE

My degree and court experience are Russian-jurisdiction; my U.S. work was immigration practice at American firms. I am not admitted to the Armenian bar, so I am applying for in-house counsel and legal-operations roles rather than court representation in Armenia — and I am happy to work alongside outside counsel where local admission is required.

ALSO

- **Highload++** (700 attendees) — organizing team, led a crew of 12; performance bonus, certificate.
- **Ethos Foundation** — HQ coordinator, Sep 2023 – Oct 2024; aid to ~100 families a day; written commendation.